

Small Fish — Go-to-Market Plan

2026-09-19 · @Someone

Summary

Small Fish grows product-first: the free match count is the demo, every search can become a public page, and Small Fish finds its own customers with its own searches. The target is 100 paying users and ~\$7K MRR by day 90, on a budget under \$1,500 a month.

The motion. Self-serve, product-led, founder-assisted. No sales team. Three engines run together:

1. **Search engine traffic** from programmatic "niche × city × gap" pages and comparison pages, each showing live match counts.
2. **Dogfood outbound:** Small Fish finds agencies that sell to local businesses, and emails each one a free, relevant list for their niche.
3. **Community and creator distribution** where AI automation and web agencies learn: YouTube, Skool, Reddit, and automation-template marketplaces.

The beachhead. AI automation agencies selling voice receptionists and booking automation to clinics, spas and home-service trades. Their offer depends on a website-visible gap, which is exactly what Small Fish finds.

90-day targets.

Metric	Day 30	Day 60	Day 90
Free sign-ups	300	900	2,000
Paying users	15	50	100
MRR	\$1,000	\$3,500	\$7,000
Programmatic pages indexed	200	1,000	3,000
Match precision (live)	≥ 90%	≥ 90%	≥ 90%

Everything below is built so one founder can run it: most of the work is automated, and the founder's time goes to content, conversations and product.

Strategy

Win one segment with one message, then widen: AI automation agencies first, web and SEO agencies second, SaaS selling to small businesses third.

Sequencing

Phase	Segment	Why now	Lead message
Days 0–60	AI automation agencies	Fastest-growing, gap-dependent offer, gathered in a few communities	"Find clinics losing bookings, before you pitch them."
Days 60–120	Web, SEO and local marketing agencies	Largest volume; already buy Maps scrapers	"Find the businesses your service actually fixes."
Days 120+	SaaS and B2B services selling to small businesses	Highest willingness to pay; need Agency and API	"Your market, qualified by what they do."

Positioning recap

- **Category:** local lead finder, relevance-first.
- **Headline:** Find local businesses by what they actually do.
- **Proof:** every match shows the sentence that proves it; unclear cases are marked, not guessed.
- **Price promise:** see the count free; pay only for matches.
- **Against Scrap.io:** they filter the listing; we read the business.

Growth loops

Three loops compound; each turns usage into new users.

flowchart LR

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A[User searches] --> B[Search becomes<br/>public page]
B --> C[Google traffic]
C --> A
A --> D[Export with<br/>proof column]
D --> E[Client or teammate<br/>sees Small Fish]
E --> A
F[Small Fish finds<br/>agencies] --> G[Free niche list<br/>by email]
G --> A

```

1. **Content loop:** anonymised, aggregated searches become public "niche × city × gap" pages with live counts, which rank and bring searchers who run the same search.
2. **Share loop:** agencies share lists with clients and teammates; free-plan exports and shared links carry a light "found with Small Fish" credit.
3. **Dogfood loop:** Small Fish searches for agencies by what they sell, and every agency it emails gets a free list built by the product it is being pitched.

Launch plan

Three phases: build proof and a waitlist before launch, launch loudly for one week, then run the engines for 90 days. Each phase has one goal and a gate.

Phase	Timing	Goal	Key actions	Gate
Pre-launch	Weeks -4 to 0	Proof and a warm audience	Benchmark published; 200 programmatic pages live; 30-day LinkedIn teardown series; 300 cold emails with free lists; 10 customer interviews; waitlist	500 waitlist sign-ups; 20 design partners using it free
Launch week	Week 1	Concentrated attention	Product Hunt; Hacker News "Show HN" on the benchmark; posts in 5 communities; waitlist email; creator videos go live; launch offer	300 sign-ups; 15 paying

Phase	Timing	Goal	Key actions	Gate
Engines on	Weeks 2-12	Repeatable acquisition	SEO pages scale to 3,000; cold email at 50/day; weekly community content; partner listings; lifecycle automations on	100 paying; MRR \$7K

Pre-launch in detail

- **Design partners:** 20 AI automation and web agencies get free Growth access for 60 days in exchange for a 20-minute call, a testimonial if happy, and permission to use their results as a case study.
- **The benchmark page:** "We ran 3 real searches through Small Fish, Scrap.io and Exa Websets. Here's how many true matches each found, and what each cost." This is the launch story.
- **Teardown series:** one LinkedIn post a day: a niche, a city and a gap ("41% of med spas in Austin don't offer online booking"), with the method shown.
- **Waitlist:** early users get 100 bonus matches and founder pricing locked for 12 months.

Launch offer

Founder pricing for the first 200 paid users: 30% off annual plans for life. Makes the launch week urgent without discounting the product long-term.

Channels and tactics

Eight channels, ranked by expected paying users per founder hour. The top three carry the plan; the rest are cheap supporting bets.

Rank	Channel	Role	Expected share of paid users by day 90	Founder hours / week
1	Dogfood cold email	Fastest first customers	35%	3

Rank	Channel	Role	Expected share of paid users by day 90	Founder hours / week
2	Programmatic SEO and comparison pages	Compounding, cheapest long-term	20% (rising to 50%+ by month 6)	3
3	Communities and creators	Trust with the beachhead	25%	4
4	Automation-template marketplaces	Distribution inside n8n and Make users' workflows	5%	1
5	Partner listings (Instantly, Smartlead, HubSpot)	Credibility and discovery	5%	1
6	LinkedIn founder content	Warm audience, design partners	5%	2
7	Affiliates	Creators and agency coaches earn recurring commission	5%	1
8	Product Hunt and Hacker News	Launch spike, backlinks	Launch week only	Launch week

1. Dogfood cold email

- **Targeting with Small Fish itself:** "Marketing and AI automation agencies in the US whose websites mention dental, med spa, HVAC or law-firm clients."
- **Offer:** a free list for their niche and city, with the count in the subject line: *"38 med spas in Dallas with no online booking."*
- **Volume:** 50 emails a day across 3 warmed inboxes on a separate domain.
- **Sequence:** 3 touches over 10 days; the list is attached in touch 1; touch 2 shows one proof row; touch 3 is a one-line bump.
- **Target:** 3% positive reply rate; 25% of positive replies become paid.

2. Programmatic SEO and comparison pages

- **Page types:** niche × city × gap ("dentists in Phoenix without online booking"), niche × city ("med spa leads in Miami"), template pages ("AI receptionist prospects"), and comparison pages ("Scrap.io alternative", "Outscraper vs Small Fish", "D7 Lead Finder alternative").
- **What makes them rank and convert:** real, live counts from the knowledge base; three sample matches with proof; a "run this search" button that starts a free count with criteria pre-filled.
- **Quality bar:** a page is published only when the count is at least 20 and the sample precision check passes, so pages are never thin.
- **Scale:** 200 pages pre-launch, 3,000 by day 90, generated and refreshed monthly by automation.

3. Communities and creators

- **Where:** AI automation Skool communities, r/AI_Agents, r/automation, r/coldemail, r/LeadGeneration, r/webdev freelancers, and YouTube channels teaching AI agency building.
- **What to post:** useful niche data and teardown threads, never pitches. One free list for any member who asks in the thread.
- **Creators:** 5 YouTube creators in the AI agency space get free Agency accounts and a 30% recurring affiliate share for a tutorial on finding clients.

4. Automation-template marketplaces

Publish free n8n and Make templates that call the Small Fish API: "Weekly new-match alert to Slack", "New matches → Instantly campaign", "New matches → HubSpot". Each template is a distribution point inside the tools our buyers already use.

5. Partner listings

List in the HubSpot marketplace, and in Instantly's and Smartlead's partner and integration directories once integrations ship. Position as the relevance layer that feeds their sequences.

6. LinkedIn founder content

The founder’s product-marketing audience is the warmest early channel for design partners and SaaS-segment buyers. Daily teardown posts pre-launch; three a week after.

7. Affiliates

30% recurring commission for 12 months, via a lightweight affiliate tool. Targets: agency coaches, course creators, automation template sellers.

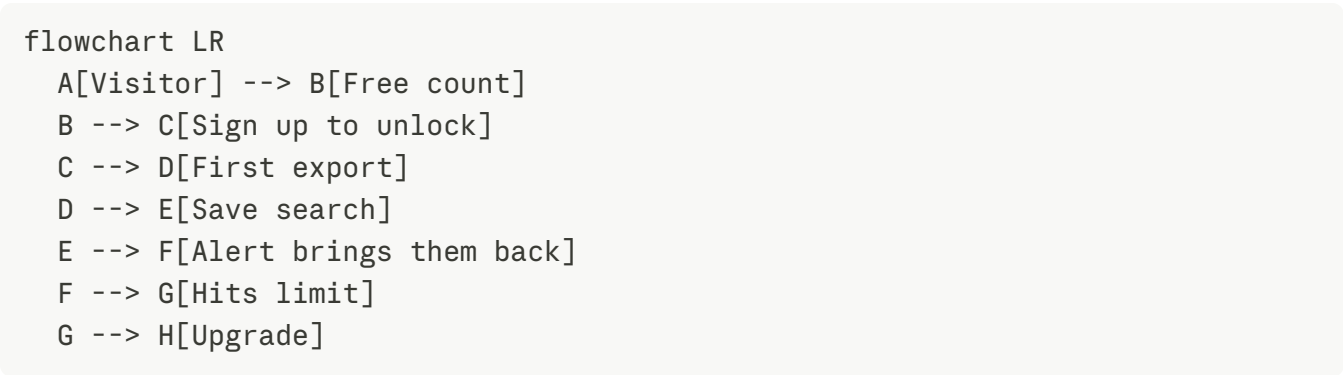
8. Product Hunt and Hacker News

Product Hunt on launch day with the demo video and founder pricing. "Show HN" built around the benchmark method, not the product pitch.

Product-led growth

The product sells itself in the first 60 seconds: a stranger types a search, sees a real count and three proven matches, and understands the value before creating an account. Every mechanic below is built into the product, not bolted on.

The PLG journey



"Aha" is the first export; "habit" is the first alert that brings new matches.

Acquisition mechanics

Mechanic	How it works	Why it grows
No-signup free count	Anyone can run a search and see a count plus 3 proven samples	Removes all friction from the demo

Mechanic	How it works	Why it grows
Public search pages	Aggregated searches become indexed pages with live counts and a "run this search" button	Every search can become SEO traffic
Shareable result links	A user can share a read-only link to a list, showing the first 10 matches to anyone	Clients and teammates see the product
"Found with Small Fish" credit	A small line in free-plan exports and shared links; removable on paid plans, white-label on Agency	Viral exposure without annoying paying users
Embeddable count widget	Agencies and bloggers embed a live "X businesses in [city] lack online booking" card	Backlinks and awareness

Activation mechanics

Mechanic	How it works
Template-first onboarding	New users pick what they sell (AI receptionist, websites, SEO, software) and get a pre-built search for their city
25 free matches, no card	Enough to run a real campaign on a small niche
Reverse trial	New sign-ups get Growth features for 14 days, then drop to Free; they feel alerts and integrations before choosing
First export in one click	"Send to Google Sheets" as the default action; no setup
Save-search nudge	After the first export: "Want new matches like these every week?"

Expansion and monetisation mechanics

Moment	In-product prompt
Count exceeds balance	"Unlock all 212 with Starter, or the top 25 now."
Third saved search on Free	"Starter keeps 5 searches running weekly."
First CSV imported into a sequencer	"Push straight to Instantly with Growth."
Second client folder created	"Agency gives each client a workspace."
Rare search (<5% match rate)	Explains the 2× rule and suggests widening, before charging

Referral and virality

- **Give 100, get 100:** a referred user and the referrer each get 100 bonus matches when the referred user makes a first export.
- **Team invites:** inviting a teammate is free and adds 25 matches to the shared pool once.
- **Client view links:** agencies share a live saved search with a client; the client sees new matches and a "get your own" prompt.

Retention mechanics

- **Alerts:** weekly "new matches" and "changed businesses" emails with 3 previews each; the strongest reason to return.
- **Credit rollover:** one month, so users don't feel penalised for a quiet week.
- **Search history:** every past search and export in one place, making Small Fish the user's record of prospecting.
- **Usage recap:** a monthly email: "You found 312 matches across 4 niches. Top performer: med spas in Dallas."

GTM automations

Twenty-two automations run the go-to-market so one founder can operate it. All run on n8n against the product's Supabase database, with Claude for writing and judging, Instantly for cold email, a lifecycle email tool for product email, PostHog for events and Stripe for billing. Nothing that contacts a prospect sends without passing a quality gate.

Acquisition

#	Automation	Trigger	Steps	Output
A1	Agency prospect finder	Weekly	Run Small Fish searches for agencies by niche served; dedupe against CRM and suppression list; score fit	350 new agency prospects a week
A2	Free-list builder	New prospect scored	Infer the agency's niche and city from its site; run the matching Small Fish search; save the list and a proof sample	A personalised list per prospect
A3	Cold email composer	List ready	Write a 3-touch sequence around the count and one proof row; similarity check against other emails that day; push to Instantly	Sequences queued for review
A4	Reply triage	New reply in Instantly	Classify (interested, question, not now, unsubscribe); draft an answer; create a free account with bonus matches for interested replies	Founder reviews drafts in one inbox
A5	Programmatic page generator	Nightly	Pick niche × city × gap combinations with ≥ 20 matches; generate the page with live count, 3 samples and FAQs; precision check; publish	50–100 new pages a night
A6	Page refresher	Monthly	Re-run counts on every page; update numbers and samples; retire pages that fall below 20	Pages stay fresh and non-thin

#	Automation	Trigger	Steps	Output
A7	Comparison page watcher	Weekly	Check competitor pricing pages; flag changes; draft updates to comparison pages	Accurate comparisons
A8	Community listener	Every 2 hours	Watch Reddit and forum keywords ("google maps leads", "scrap.io alternative", "find clinics without booking"); summarise threads worth answering	A daily digest of 5-10 threads
A9	Teardown post drafter	Daily	Pick an interesting niche statistic from the knowledge base; draft a LinkedIn post and a chart	One post draft a day

Activation and conversion

#	Automation	Trigger	Steps	Output
B1	Welcome and first search	Sign-up	Email with a pre-built search for their stated offer and city	Faster first export
B2	Stuck-at-count nudge	Ran a count, no unlock in 24h	Email with the 3 samples and one-click unlock	Recovers hesitant users
B3	First-export follow-up	First export	Tip on using the proof column in emails; prompt to save the search	Drives habit
B4	Reverse-trial countdown	Day 10 and 13 of trial	Show what they used (alerts, pushes); offer founder pricing	Trial conversion
B5	Upgrade-moment email	Hit a plan limit	Personalised upgrade offer based on the limit hit	Timely upsell

#	Automation	Trigger	Steps	Output
B6	Product-qualified lead alert	PQL score crosses threshold	Slack alert to founder with the user's searches, company and suggested message	Founder touches the best 5%

Retention and expansion

#	Automation	Trigger	Steps	Output
C1	Saved-search alerts	Schedule per search	Re-run in batch; diff against last run; email new and changed matches	The core habit loop
C2	Monthly usage recap	1st of month	Summarise matches, niches, exports; suggest a new search	Reminds users of value
C3	Churn-risk detector	No login 21 days, or declining searches	Tag at risk; send a "new matches waiting" email with real counts	Saves quiet accounts
C4	Cancellation save	Cancel clicked	Offer pause, downgrade or a pack instead; capture reason	Lower churn; reason data
C5	Failed payment recovery	Stripe payment fails	Smart retries plus 3 emails with a one-click update link	Recovers involuntary churn

Feedback and proof

#	Automation	Trigger	Steps	Output
D1	Review and testimonial ask	3rd export, or positive feedback	Ask for a G2 or Capterra review, or a one-line testimonial	Social proof

#	Automation	Trigger	Steps	Output
D2	Wrong-result loop	Match reported wrong	Refund credit; add to benchmark queue; weekly summary of failure patterns	Quality improves; trust kept

Every automation logs to one GTM events table, so the analytics below can attribute sign-ups, revenue and churn to the automation that touched them.

Analytics in the product

Analytics serve three audiences: the founder (is growth working?), the engine (is it accurate and profitable?), and the user (is Small Fish paying off?). One event model feeds all three.

Event model

Every event carries user ID, workspace ID, plan, session, timestamp, acquisition source (UTM, referral code, page slug, cold-email campaign ID) and, where relevant, search ID.

Stage	Events
Acquisition	<code>page_viewed</code> (with page type and slug), <code>count_started_anonymous</code> , <code>template_clicked</code> , <code>shared_link_opened</code> , <code>widget_clicked</code>
Search	<code>search_typed</code> , <code>criteria_confirmed</code> , <code>clarification_answered</code> , <code>count_completed</code> (candidates, matches, couldn't-tell, sample match rate), <code>rare_search_warned</code>
Conversion	<code>signup_completed</code> , <code>matches_unlocked</code> (count, cost), <code>limit_hit</code> (which limit), <code>checkout_started</code> , <code>plan_started</code> , <code>pack_purchased</code>
Value	<code>export_completed</code> (destination, rows), <code>proof_opened</code> , <code>search_saved</code> , <code>alert_sent</code> , <code>alert_opened</code> , <code>alert_matches_unlocked</code>

Stage	Events
Quality	result_reported (criterion type, reason), credit_refunded, couldnt_tell_viewed
Retention	login, plan_changed, cancel_clicked (reason), plan_cancelled, payment_failed
Engine (server)	business_read (cold or warm, pages, rendering used), judgment_made (model, tokens, cost, verdict), profile_refreshed

Internal dashboards

Dashboard	Key views	Checked
Growth	Visitors → counts → sign-ups → first export → paid, by source; MRR, new, expansion, churn	Daily
Activation	Time to first export; share exporting within 24h; drop-off by step	Weekly
Channel ROI	Sign-ups, paid users and MRR by channel, campaign, page and automation	Weekly
Quality	Precision on benchmark; report rate by criterion type; couldn't-tell rate by category	Daily
Unit economics	Cost per business (cold vs warm), cost per match by match-rate band, warm-read share, gross margin by plan	Weekly
SEO	Pages indexed, impressions, clicks, counts started per page, sign-ups per page	Weekly
Retention	Cohort retention by signup month and first template; saved searches per user; alert open-to- unlock rate	Monthly

Product-qualified lead score

A simple, transparent score out of 100, recalculated daily. Users above 60 trigger the founder alert (automation B6).

Signal	Points
Exported 2+ times in first 7 days	25
Saved 2+ searches	15
Hit a plan limit	20
Work email on an agency or SaaS domain	15
Created a second workspace or invited a teammate	15
Pushed to an integration	10

Analytics for users

Users see their own value, which reinforces retention and makes upgrades feel earned.

- **Search insights:** for each search, total candidates, matches, couldn't-tell, and the match rate, plus the most common reasons businesses failed a criterion ("62% already use online booking").
- **Market snapshot:** a small chart of how many businesses in the area meet each criterion; agencies screenshot these into pitches.
- **Saved-search trends:** new matches per week and businesses that changed status.
- **Usage and spend:** matches used, rolled over, and cost per match this month.
- **Outcome tracking (optional):** users mark matches as contacted, replied or won, or sync these from their CRM; Small Fish shows reply and win rates per search. This is also our strongest source of proof for marketing, used only in aggregate and with consent.

Tooling

PostHog for product events, funnels and session replays; the product database for engine and billing metrics; a simple SQL dashboard layer for unit economics. All events flow to one warehouse table so channel attribution joins cleanly with revenue.

Sales assist, lifecycle and retention

No sales team, but the founder personally touches the top 5% of users: product-qualified leads, Agency prospects and anyone about to churn after heavy use.

Founder-assist plays

Play	Who	What the founder does	Time
PQL outreach	PQL score above 60	Short personal email: "Saw you're prospecting med spas in Texas; here are 2 searches that work well for that"	5 min each
Agency onboarding call	New Agency plan or 3+ workspaces	20-minute call to set up client workspaces and templates	20 min
Design partner check-in	Pre-launch partners	Monthly 15-minute call; collect quotes and outcome numbers	15 min
Save call	Paid user cancelling after 2+ months of use	Personal note asking what failed; offer a fix or a pause	5 min

Lifecycle stages

Stage	Definition	Goal	Main levers
Visitor	Landed, no count	Run a free count	Pre-filled searches on every page
Explorer	Ran a count, no account	Sign up	3 proven samples; "unlock with 25 free matches"
Activated	First export	Save a search	Save-search nudge; alert preview
Habitual	Opened 2+ alerts, 2+ exports a month	Upgrade	Limit prompts; reverse-trial memory
Paid	Any paid plan	Expand	Integrations, workspaces, more searches

Stage	Definition	Goal	Main levers
At risk	Paid, inactive 21+ days	Re-engage	Real new-match counts; pause option
Churned	Cancelled	Win back	Quarterly "what's new" email with counts for their old searches

Retention plays

1. **Alerts are sacred.** They are the reason to come back; their deliverability, accuracy and usefulness get the same attention as the core search.
2. **Pause, don't cancel.** A 1–3 month pause keeps saved searches and history alive.
3. **Annual nudge at month 2.** Users who reach their second renewal get an annual-plan offer at two months free.
4. **Win-back with real data.** Churned users get their old saved search re-run: "27 new med spas in Dallas match since you left."

Metrics and operating cadence

One weekly scorecard of ten numbers decides where the founder spends the next week; anything red for two weeks in a row gets a written fix.

Weekly scorecard

#	Metric	Green	Red
1	Free counts started	≥ 1,000/week by day 60	< 300
2	Count → sign-up	≥ 20%	< 10%
3	Sign-up → export in 24h	≥ 50%	< 30%
4	New paying users	≥ 10/week by day 60	< 3
5	Net new MRR	≥ \$700/week by day 60	< \$200
6	Cold email positive reply rate	≥ 3%	< 1%
7	SEO sign-ups	Growing week on week	Flat 3 weeks
8	Live match precision (audit)	≥ 90%	< 85%

#	Metric	Green	Red
9	Blended cost per match	≤ \$0.04	> \$0.06
10	Paid churn (monthly, trailing)	≤ 6%	> 10%

Rhythm

- **Daily (15 min):** growth and quality dashboards; reply triage; PQL alerts.
- **Weekly (1 hour, Monday):** scorecard review; pick one channel to double and one to fix; review automation logs.
- **Monthly (half day):** cohort retention, unit economics, pricing experiments, SEO page performance; update this plan.
- **Quarterly:** segment review: is it time to shift the lead segment?

Decision rules

- If **count** → **sign-up** is below 10% for 2 weeks: the samples aren't convincing; improve proof display before adding traffic.
- If **precision** drops below 85%: pause SEO page generation and cold email until fixed. Trust is the product.
- If **cost per match** exceeds \$0.06: tighten the rare-search rule and scan budget before any new acquisition spend.
- If a channel produces **no paying user in 4 weeks**: cut it and move its hours to the best channel.

90-day launch calendar

Four pre-launch weeks, a launch week, then eleven weeks of engines; each block ends with one milestone that must be true before moving on.

Weeks	Focus	Actions	Milestone
-4 to -3	Proof	Run the benchmark (3 searches × 3 tools); fix precision gaps; set up domain, inboxes and warm-up; PostHog events in place	Benchmark shows Small Fish ahead; precision ≥ 90%

Weeks	Focus	Actions	Milestone
-2 to -1	Warm audience	200 SEO pages live; waitlist page; daily LinkedIn teardowns; recruit 20 design partners; automations A1-A4 on at 20 emails/day	500 waitlist; 20 partners active
1	Launch	Product Hunt; Show HN on the benchmark; 5 community posts; waitlist email; 2 creator videos; founder pricing	300 sign-ups; 15 paying
2-4	Activation	Automations B1-B6 on; fix top onboarding drop-off; cold email to 50/day; 10 teardown threads	50% export in 24h; 30 paying
5-8	Scale content	SEO to 1,000 pages; 5 comparison pages; n8n and Make templates published; affiliate program live	50 paying; SEO sign-ups growing weekly
9-12	Retention and expansion	Alerts polished; C1-C5 on; Agency plan and HubSpot and Instantly pushes; first case study; start web-agency segment messaging	100 paying; \$7K MRR; churn ≤ 6%

Founder's weekly hours at steady state

Activity	Hours
Product and quality	20
Content (LinkedIn, community threads, videos)	6
Conversations (replies, PQLs, partners)	5
Reviewing automations and the scorecard	3
Total	34

Budget, tool stack and risks

The whole GTM runs for roughly \$800 to \$1,300 a month, mostly model and data costs that scale with usage. Figures below are approximate planning numbers; confirm current vendor prices when subscribing.

Monthly budget

Item	Tool	Approx. monthly cost
Cold email sending	Instantly (or Smartlead), 3 inboxes on a separate domain	\$60-100
Automations	n8n (self-hosted or cloud)	\$20-50
Database and auth	Supabase	\$25-75
Hosting	Vercel	\$20-50
Product analytics	PostHog (free tier to start)	\$0-50
Lifecycle email	Loops or Resend	\$0-50
Affiliate tracking	Rewardful or similar	\$50
Model costs for free counts, SEO pages and dogfood lists	Claude API	\$300-600
Candidate gap-fill	Google Places API	\$100-200
Creators and design partners	Free accounts plus commission	\$0 upfront
Total		~\$800-1,300

GTM risks

Risk	Signal	Response
Cold email deliverability drops	Bounce > 3% or opens collapse	Lower volume; rotate inboxes; verify every address; lean on communities

Risk	Signal	Response
Programmatic pages judged thin by Google	Indexing stalls, impressions flat	Raise the page quality bar; add unique data and charts; prune weak pages
AI agency segment smaller or poorer than expected	Low conversion from that segment by day 45	Shift lead message to web and SEO agencies early
Free counts abused, costs spike	Cost per sign-up above \$1	Tighten anonymous limits; cache aggressively; require login after 2 counts
Founder time swallowed by support	Support > 5 hours a week	Better docs, in-app explanations, reply templates
Competitor copies the positioning	Scrap.io or others adopt "relevance" messaging	Publish benchmarks monthly; lean on proof and pay-per-match, which are hard for volume sellers to match